

Hard drive prices soar 28 percent after Thai floods

The average price for a hard drive jumped 28 percent during the fourth quarter as a result of the Thai floods. While prices will decline by 3 percent in the first quarter and by 9 percent in the second quarter, they will remain inflated above 2011 levels throughout 2012, IHS said in an analyst report.

Just 124 million hard drives were shipped during the fourth quarter, the peak of the holiday season, down 26 percent from last year. The disk-drive industry is not expected to return to growth until the third quarter. Hard-drive sales are typically strongest near the end of the third quarter and the beginning of the fourth, as OEMs begin ramping up purchases for holiday sales.

IHS said shipments should increase 2 percent during the third quarter, to 178 million units. By the fourth, the drive industry is expected to sell 185 million drives, 45 percent above the flood-ravaged shipments of the fourth quarter 2011.

Prices however, may remain high because of long-term contracts as well as the impact of the Seagate-Samsung and Western Digital-Hitachi mergers, which have consolidated the industry.

Floods ravaged Thailand from mid-2011 until January. Hundreds were killed. The World Bank said that the largest portion of the damage at about \$35 billion, was to manufacturing.

RIM sets up server to intercept BBM data in real-time



It looks like Research In Motion's woes in India are finally coming to an end, with the Canadian mobile manufacturer delivering a real-time data interception mechanism for its BlackBerry

Messenger (BBM) services to the Indian government.

RIM's troubles started back in July 2010, when the Indian government requested access to BlackBerry data for internal security purposes, later even threatening manufacturer with a country-wide ban of services. RIM has finally set up a server in Mumbai for the task, allowing various government agencies to monitor BBM data feeds in real-time.

Mozilla to unveil Boot2Gecko at MWC

Mozilla will be making a major announcement at an MWC, and according to the latest industry speculation, the non-profit foundation will be unveiling the first mobile device running the Boot to Gecko (B2G) OS.

At MWC, Mozilla will also finally be opening the Mozilla Marketplace to developers, seeking to populate it with open web apps for the Firefox

browser and Boot to Gecko devices, using only CSS, HTML5, and JavaScript. Similar to Chrome OS, the OS will be primarily browser-based. Mozilla will be using its Firefox Web APIs for HTML5 and JavaScript scripts to interact with the device's hardware.

The first B2G device is expected to be made by LG. It will be a developer phone to assist in app development for the newly created app store.

The best office suite ever – released



The Document Foundation (TDF) has released a new version of LibreOffice, the popular open source productivity suite. Officially the third major release, LibreOffice 3.5 will apparently show end users the improvements derived from the new development strategy adopted in September 2010, involving a combined effort of full time and volunteer hackers.

According to TDF, in the 16 months it took to develop the latest version of LibreOffice, with 80 developers working on it each month, producing over thirty thousand code commits. The latest version is being called "the best free office suite ever".

New features are spread across Writer, Impress/Draw, Calc, and Base applications. Writer has a new built-in Grammar checker for English

and other languages, improved typographical features, an interactive word count window with real time updates. Impress and Draw get an improved importer of custom shapes and Smart Art from PPT/PPTX, a new display switch for the presenter's console, new line ends for improved diagrams, and Microsoft Visio import filter.

Calc now has support for up to 10,000 sheets, a new multi-line input area, new Calc functions, better performances when importing files from other office suites, multiple selections in autofilter, and an unlimited number of rules for conditional formatting. Base will get a new integrated PostgreSQL native driver. The biggest change for the whole suite is the online update checker, which will notify users when a new version of the suite is available.